

To begin with, place the distribution file in a directory. Follow specific installation methods for installing different PHP versions. To install PHP 4, extract the files to C:\ and then the ZIP file will expand into a folder named php-4.3.7-Win32. Similarly, if you are installing PHP 5, extract the file to C:\php as the zip file does not expand in the same way as PHP4.

Installing PHP on your operating system helps in many ways. It can perform any task a CGI program can do. Like a CGI, PHP generates dynamic page content, collect form data, and even sends and accepts cookies. Moreover, as an embedded scripting language, PHP has certain other utilities like:

- Used for server-side scripting
- Writing client-side GUI applications, and
- Used for Command line scripting

Once installed on your Windows system, you can download some extensions for additional functionality.

1.2 Basics of PHP

Apart from a simple text editor, no other additional software is required to create PHP code.

First of all in order to print the information about PHP on your server type the following code into the text editor installed on your computer.

```
<?
phpinfo();
?>
```

This single line of PHP code `phpinfo`, commands the server to print a standard information table. This provides information about the server setup. In the above example, the line ends with a semicolon and should not be missed, or else you will get an error.

Save this script as `phpinfo.php`, and upload it to the server. Access the URL of the script with your browser. If you can access the script, you will see detailed information about PHP on your server.